

Past events and background actions

Teaching guide

Put a finished event in its time context.

Understand the distinction

The past simple presents a finished event or a past state: I arrived at six; the room was quiet.
The past continuous presents an activity in progress around a past time: I was waiting at six.

Combine them to show background and an event: I was cooking when the phone rang. This does not always mean the first activity stopped. Add then, before, or after when the order needs to be explicit.

Compare the patterns

EVENT

The bus arrived at six.

A completed event.

BACKGROUND

I was waiting at the stop.

An activity in progress.

TOGETHER

I was waiting when the bus arrived.

The arrival happened during the wait.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Choose: At eight yesterday, I ____ dinner. (was cooking / cook)

2. Which happened during the walk: I was walking when it began to rain?

3. Does was reading when the phone rang prove the reading stopped?

Use it in your own life

Write two sentences about a past event and its background.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. was cooking

An activity was in progress at a past time.

2. It began to rain.

The walk is the background activity.

3. No. The sentence does not state that.

The reader may have continued.

One possible response

I was working at home yesterday. A neighbor knocked on the door.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-14.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Write two sentences about a past event and its background.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.